

Coping with Bereavement and Grief

Bereavement and grief are individual, yet universal experiences that nearly everyone faces within their lifetime. Everyone experiences loss in their own personal way. Many can navigate grief with the support of those who are already in their lives, but others may need more help. There are resources and organizations available to ensure individuals receive the appropriate care they need. The type of support required can be influenced by the nature and timing of the loss, the specific resources available, and many other factors.



Understanding Bereavement and Grief

In the simplest of terms, bereavement is a period of grief and mourning after a loss, while grief is a person's emotional response to a loss. Below are more comprehensive definitions based on the opinions of several experts in the field.

Bereavement

The overarching experience of coping with loss and change. It is the emotional and psychological condition experienced after a loss, typically due to death, but it can also apply to non-death-related

losses. Bereavement often encompasses both inward and outward expressions of grief and the cultural, social, and personal practices that help individuals process and adjust to the loss, often through rituals and support from loved ones. It usually involves a period of grieving.

Grief

The emotional, mental, and/or physical response to a loss, often due to death but also encompassing other life changes, such as the end of relationships, loss of identity, or illness. Sometimes people experience periods of grief in anticipation of a loss. Grief is deeply personal and can occur differently in everyone, shaped by the nature of the relationship, the degrees of support, circumstances of the loss, cultural influences, and individual coping mechanisms as well as other considerations. While it can be an intense experience, it is considered a natural human reaction to loss that generally subsides over time for most people.

Additional [definitions](#) provided by the National Cancer Institute and the American Psychological Association for [bereavement](#)  and [grief](#) .

Examples of how grief can be expressed:

- Sadness
- Anger
- Guilt
- Confusion
- Relief
- Anxiety
- Numbness
- Helplessness
- Fatigue
- Loss of appetite
- Sleep disturbances
- And many more...

Strategies for coping with grief and loss:

- Support from friends, family, and/or other known community members
- Cultural, social, religious, faith, or other beliefs or rituals
- Local or virtual grief support groups
- Community-based or virtual grief counseling services
- Grief peer support services
- Artistic expression
- Physical movement and exercise
- Outreach to a mental health professional

Prolonged Grief Disorder (PGD)

Although most people experience periods of grief and bereavement after the death of an individual without long-term mental health concerns, some may experience symptoms that could benefit from additional help. In 2022, the American Psychiatric Association added [Prolonged Grief Disorder \(PGD\)](#)  to the DSM-5-TR [after clearly distinguishing PGD as its own distinct diagnosis](#) . Major features of the [criteria for PGD](#) include, but are not limited to:

- Intense yearning or thoughts about the deceased
- Significant and persistent degree of distress
- Significant decrease in functioning
- Symptoms that last more than one year in adults and six months in children and youth

PGD is only one form of grief that can cause extraordinary challenges for individuals. People can also experience other difficult grief reactions. People who are, or think they are, experiencing PGD or are having an especially hard time processing their grief, may seek clinical care, such as individual or group psychotherapy to support them through their loss. Many may also find other supports, such as grief peer support, helpful with this experience.

[Grief Reaction and Prolonged Grief Disorder](#) can provide more information about the epidemiology, history, and evaluation of PGD.

Federal Bereavement Care Efforts

SAMHSA is committed and working alongside federal partners and experts on national efforts to provide high-quality bereavement and grief care.

- [Report: Overview of Bereavement and Grief Services in the United States \(PDF | 760 KB\)](#) – In 2023, Congress directed the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) Office of the Assistant Secretary for Planning and Evaluation (ASPE) to perform a landscape scan about grief and bereavement supports. SAMHSA participated as an advising agency to ASPE during the development process of the report.
- [Interventions to Improve Care of Bereaved Persons | Effective Health Care \(EHC\) Program](#) – In 2023, Congress directed HHS Agency for Healthcare Research and Quality (AHRQ) to establish an evidence base for what constitutes high-quality bereavement and grief care, and AHRQ commissioned a systematic review.

Need Help?

If you or someone you know is struggling or in crisis, help is available. Call or text [988](tel:988) or chat 988lifeline.org .

To learn how to get support for mental health, drug, and alcohol issues, visit [FindSupport.gov](https://findsupport.gov).

To locate treatment facilities or providers, visit [FindTreatment.gov](https://findtreatment.gov) or call SAMHSA's National Helpline at [800-662-HELP \(4357\)](tel:800-662-HELP(4357)).

Grief Support Resources

General Resources

Population-Specific

Helping Others

What to Do if Someone is Dying or After Someone Has Passed Away

After a loss, the emotional need to grieve can be overshadowed by practical needs. If someone you know is in need of [end-of-life](#) care, knowing how to initiate sometimes difficult [conversations, prepare for end-of-life care, and make important decisions](#) about this period of life can be helpful. Hospice care can be an important resource for some and a source of grief counseling for many families and caregivers. This resource can help assure that you find a quality [hospice provider](#) (PDF | [1.3 MB](#)).

There are government resources available after a loss and a [checklist](#)  to help identify other things that may need to be completed in the days and months afterwards.

- [Dealing with the death of a loved one | USAGov](#)
- [What to do when someone dies | SSA](#)
- [What To Do After Someone Dies | National Institute on Aging](#)
- [Leave for Funerals and Bereavement | OPM](#)

If you lost your health insurance because you were covered under the policy of the person who passed away, this is considered a [“qualifying life event”](#). You can use this [map](#) to determine whether or not you are eligible for [Medicaid](#) or a [Marketplace](#) plan through your state.

National Grief Awareness Week

National Grief Awareness Week is observed in the first week of December and is a time to raise awareness about grief and loss. This observance aims to decrease the stigma surrounding grief by acknowledging that it is a natural response to loss, while also highlighting that some people have more difficulties processing grief and may need additional support.

Visit [National Grief Awareness Week Observance](#) to find a shareable social media toolkit, webinars, and more resources.

Inclusion of resources on this webpage is for general educational purposes only and does not imply a formal endorsement by the Center

for Mental Health Services, the Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration, or the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services.

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<https://www.samhsa.gov/communities/coping-bereavement-grief>